

Buy, Rebuild, Compound

A playbook for a developer-led software acquisition business — lessons from Bending Spoons, structured with Disciplined Entrepreneurship

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Executive summary

Your instinct is correct, and it has a name: **acquisition entrepreneurship** — “buy then build.” For a team that is strong at building software and weak at sales and marketing, the hardest and slowest thing to manufacture is *distribution*: a base of users who already pay and already trust a product. Buying it, rather than building it from zero, sidesteps the single highest-failure stage of any venture — finding product-market fit — and lets you start where your edge actually is: making working software faster, cheaper, and better.

This is precisely the model that **Bending Spoons** rode from a \$40,000 seed in 2013 to a Nasdaq listing in July 2026 at roughly an \$18 billion valuation. They buy established digital products with loyal, low-churn user bases, rebuild the technology on a shared internal platform, sharpen monetization, run lean, and hold forever. Their story is the central case study of this document — both for what to copy and for what a small, bootstrapped team should deliberately *not* copy.

Two hard truths frame everything that follows. First, **the most dangerous instinct you bring to this is your own strength**: the urge to rewrite the code you just bought. Rewriting from scratch is the classic way these deals die, and resisting it is the discipline that separates acquirers who compound from ones who stall. Second, **buying does not make your marketing weakness disappear — it relocates it**. Acquisition solves the cold-start problem; *growing* an acquired product still needs demand generation. Be honest about whether you are buying to harvest cash or to scale, because they are different games.

The recommended path is to **start small and stair-step**: buy one profitable micro-SaaS in the \$10k–\$500k range with your own cash, run it with the customer-centric rigor of the *Disciplined Entrepreneurship* framework, build a reusable operating platform as you go, and compound from cash flow into the next deal. Bending Spoons is your north star for *how to operate*; it is not your template for *how to finance* — their engine runs on billions in debt and equity you neither have nor need at the start.

This document has three parts: (1) the Bending Spoons case study and the lessons to draw from it; (2) the practical reality of bootstrapped micro-acquisitions at your scale; and (3) a concrete way to structure and run your company using the 24-step Disciplined Entrepreneurship framework, adapted from a build-from-scratch model to a buy-and-operate one.

Part I — The Bending Spoons case study

1.1 Why they are worth studying

Bending Spoons is the purest, most successful public example of the exact strategy you are contemplating, executed at scale. They did not invent a category; they bought products other people had already validated, then won on operational excellence. Their CEO Luca Ferrari frames the whole philosophy as **“minimizing luck”**: after their own from-scratch app (a self-writing diary called Evertale) failed, they concluded that finding product-market fit is dominated by luck, whereas *operating* a business that already has it is dominated by skill. So they stopped gambling on 0-to-1 and started buying 1-to-n. That single reframing is the most important idea in this entire report, and it is directly transferable to a team that would rather build than sell.

1.2 The numbers, briefly

Bending Spoons was founded in 2013 (Copenhagen, moved to Milan in 2014) on about \$40,000 of seed capital left over from the failed Evertale venture. Its **first acquisition, in 2014, was a \$10,000 keyboard app** — they improved it, roughly doubled the money, and repeated the pattern for a decade, progressively shifting from building their own apps (Remini, Splice, FiLMiC Pro) to a pure acquire-and-operate model. Over 13 years they have made **50+ acquisitions and never sold one**.

The recent scale is worth internalizing, and so are the caveats:

Metric	Figure	Note
2025 revenue	\$1.31B	Up 95% year-over-year (2024: \$671M; 2023: \$387M)
Organic growth, 2025	~13%	The other ~82 points of growth were <i>bought</i> , not built
2025 GAAP net income	≈ breakeven (−\$0.2M)	Interest, amortization, and reorg costs swamp operating profit
2025 operating income	\$278M	The “real” operating engine
2025 adjusted net income	\$375.6M	After ~\$335M of add-backs — larger than operating income
2025 <i>pro-forma</i> net income	~\$22.4M	Combining AOL + Vimeo + Eventbrite as if owned all year
Total debt (Q1 2026)	~\$4.36B	Net debt ~\$3.6B; 2025 interest expense \$142.6M (+337%)
IPO (Jul 1, 2026, Nasdaq: BSP)	Raised ~\$1.68B	Priced at \$29; ~\$18.4B valuation; popped ~40% to >\$25B intraday

The reason four different “profit” numbers appear above is important, and it is the crux of the skeptical case against them (made most sharply by Forbes in July 2026): **against the ~\$3.3B they paid for AOL, Vimeo, and Eventbrite, the combined pro-forma profit of the whole company was about \$22 million.** That is a business bought with debt and equity, not with its own cash flow — a machine that works beautifully as long as capital is cheap and available, and gets stress-tested hard when it is not. Keep this in view: it is the single biggest argument for *your* version being bootstrapped and debt-light.

1.3 The playbook mechanics

Strip away the scale and Bending Spoons runs a simple, three-step compounding loop, stated plainly in their own IPO filing:

1. **Acquire** a digital business with a large, forecastable revenue base — at a disciplined price.
2. **Transform and optimize** — rebuild the technology, reorganize (usually shrink) the team, redesign the product, and sharpen monetization.
3. **Reinvest** the earnings, plus prudent incremental debt, into the next acquisition. Repeat.

Underneath that loop sit five mechanics worth studying in detail.

A shared platform that every acquisition inherits on day one. Outsiders call it the “Spoon Engine”; internally it is a set of proprietary services that get deployed into each newly bought product immediately — a better checkout and billing stack (internally “Juno”), real-time lifetime-value prediction that feeds pricing (“Minerva”), marketing attribution (“Xina”), shared authentication (“Galf”), propagation of proven UX patterns across the portfolio (“Matrix”), and a heavy experimentation toolkit running hundreds of concurrent A/B tests on shared data infrastructure. **This is the compounding advantage.** The day they close a deal, a product that could never previously run a thousand pricing experiments inherits the accumulated learning of the entire portfolio. This — not any single acquisition — is their real moat.

A disciplined sourcing funnel. In 2025 they **sourced ~2,500 opportunities, analyzed ~200 in depth, and completed 6.** They estimate 1,000+ future targets, mostly businesses with \$50M–\$500M in revenue. The lesson is not the absolute numbers; it is the *ratio*. Great acquirers look at a hundred things to buy a few, and they win by walking away.

Clear target criteria. Ferrari’s stated filters: **predictability** above all (can they forecast the business over a long horizon once it is on their platform, including AI-disruption risk?); a genuine belief they can **improve it dramatically** (“if we don’t see that we can make a big difference, we don’t expect to be able to make an appealing offer”); and **recurring, subscription revenue with a loyal base** — roughly 79% of their new-customer revenue in 2025 came from *organic* channels, and they deliberately avoid ad-dependent businesses because that revenue is volatile and hard to forecast. They claim to have been the *highest* bidder on every deal they have won — meaning they win on conviction and price discipline, not by sneaking in cheap.

Monetization treated as an engineering discipline. After acquiring, they convert free and one-time users to subscriptions, raise prices on loyal users, and cap free tiers — always instrumented and A/B-tested. The concrete examples are instructive: Evernote’s free tier was cut to **50 notes total** and its price raised sharply (reports range from +63% to +86% depending on the base year); StreamYard’s price rose **~80%** (\$25–\$45/month); WeTransfer’s free plan was capped at **10 transfers/month**. The underlying principle from the *Disciplined Entrepreneurship* book applies exactly: they accept some churn as long as revenue-per-user rises faster than users leave.

Rebuild the tech, flatten the org, run lean. Evernote is their showcase: they migrated a monolith to microservices, flattened management from four layers to two, roughly doubled the pace of product releases with a far smaller team, tripled sync speed, shipped 200+ features, and drove net revenue retention to 99%. This is also where the controversy lives — the transformation typically involves **deep layoffs** (Evernote ~82%, WeTransfer 75%, komoot ~75%), softened by comparatively generous severance (around 16 weeks’ pay, a year of health insurance, a pro-rated bonus, and visa help).

Own it forever. In 13 years and 50+ deals they have never sold a business, and every deal is underwritten assuming a permanent hold. Ferrari’s line for the model is “like private equity had a baby with Google.” The closest real analog is **Constellation Software** — the

Canadian serial acquirer of vertical-market software that has compounded ~28%+ per year for two decades by buying niche software cheaply and never selling.

1.4 The culture and capital engine

Two more elements make the machine run. **Talent density:** in 2025 they received ~800,000 job applications and hired 286 people — roughly 1 in 2,800 — keeping a core team of only ~620 “Spooners” running 100+ brands. Revenue per employee climbed from \$1.12M (2023) to \$2.57M (2025), among the highest in software, and they have leaned hard into AI (the share of pull requests authored or co-authored by AI jumped from under 10% in early 2025 to over 90% a year later). They pay London-level salaries in Milan, run 100% fixed compensation with no bonuses, and use a “controversial principles” document to make candidates self-select on culture.

Capital allocation: acquire → transform → reinvest earnings plus prudent debt → repeat, with relentless price discipline and a dual-class share structure that keeps the founders in control (>80% of voting power). The IPO, in Ferrari’s framing, is “just one more tool” to access the capital that fuels acquisitions.

1.5 The uncomfortable truths (what not to copy)

A balanced reading of Bending Spoons has to hold the criticisms alongside the admiration:

- **It runs on leverage.** Growth is bought, not organic (only ~13% organic in 2025), and it is financed with ~\$4.4B of debt whose interest cost tripled in a year. The whole model assumes continuous access to cheap capital. A bootstrapped team must invert this: grow slowly on your own cash, and treat debt as a rare, carefully-sized tool — not the engine.
- **“Adjusted” profit hides recurring costs.** Their add-backs (restructuring, transaction costs) are larger than reported operating income, and for a serial acquirer, “one-time” reorganization costs recur every year. When you evaluate your *own* deals, be suspicious of any profit figure that depends on ignoring costs that will keep happening.
- **The reputational cost is real.** Aggressive layoffs and price hikes generate genuine user and press backlash. At their scale it is absorbed; at your scale, in a niche community, goodwill is the asset you paid for, and torching it can destroy the value overnight.
- **Platform dependency.** A third of their payments run through the App Store and Google Play, which take 15–30%. Any business you buy that sits on someone else’s platform inherits that platform’s power over you.

1.6 Ten lessons, translated to your scale

#	Bending Spoons practice	What it means for a bootstrapped dev team
1	Minimize luck: buy proven PMF	Don’t gamble on 0-to-1. Buy a product people already pay for; spend your talent

		on operating it, not discovering it.
2	Build a shared platform, deploy everywhere	From deal # 1, extract reusable infrastructure (auth, billing, analytics, support, experimentation). Each new buy should inherit it. This is your future moat.
3	Disciplined sourcing funnel	Look at ~50–100 businesses to buy one. Your edge is the willingness to walk away.
4	Buy recurring, organic, low-churn revenue	Prefer subscription micro-SaaS with word-of-mouth/organic acquisition. Avoid ad- and SEO-dependent businesses you can't defend.
5	Monetization is engineering	Instrument everything. Test pricing. Raising a too-low price is often the single highest-ROI change you can make post-close.
6	Retention is the whole game	With no contracts, product quality and brand affinity <i>are</i> the moat. Measure net revenue retention obsessively.
7	Rebuild tech — but incrementally	Modernize under the hood to cut cost and stop breakage. Do not do the big-bang rewrite (see §2.4).
8	Stay lean; lean on AI	A tiny team can run several products if the platform and AI do the heavy lifting. Revenue-per-person is your scoreboard.
9	Be disciplined on price; model buy-and-hold	Price every deal on the cash it throws off if you hold it forever. Be willing to be the high bidder on conviction, and to walk on price.

Part II — The bootstrapped reality at your scale

Bending Spoons shows you the *operating* playbook. But their financing model is irrelevant to a team starting out. This part translates the strategy into the world of \$10k–\$500k deals you can actually do.

2.1 What to buy — and what to avoid

Your edge is building and operating software; your gap is demand generation. That single fact should decide what you buy.

Buy: profitable micro-SaaS or genuinely product-led tools with organic or word-of-mouth acquisition, sticky/recurring revenue, and a real (if small) moat — a niche community, an integration, switching costs, a brand. These reward exactly what you're good at: shipping fixes and improvements faster than a solo founder could.

Avoid (at first): content/affiliate sites, Amazon FBA, and anything whose only growth lever is a channel you can't defend. Content sites live or die by Google, and the 2024–2026 core updates and AI Overviews have gutted independents (HouseFresh lost ~91% of its search traffic; Retro Dodo ~85%). FBA lives or dies by Amazon (the aggregator Thrasio paid 4–6× at the 2021 peak and filed for bankruptcy in 2024). These put you at the mercy of the very marketing/SEO channels you are least equipped to save.

2.2 Where to buy

Marketplace	Best for	Typical deal size	Notes
Tiny Acquisitions	A cheap first “rep”	~\$300–\$100k	Minimal vetting — buyer beware. Not to be confused with Wilkinson's “Tiny.”
Acquire.com	Bootstrapped SaaS	<\$250k–\$1M+	Your most natural home. 500k+ buyers, \$500M+ closed. Self-serve but vetted.
Flippa	Widest selection	A few \$k–\$10M+	Noisiest; lightest vetting, so diligence is entirely on you.
Empire Flippers	Curated quality	~\$25k–\$10M+	Requires ≥\$2k/mo profit to list; rejects

Motion Invest	Content sites only	~\$1k–\$50k	~91% of submissions. Buyers pay no fee. Beginner-friendly, but content = the channel risk you want to avoid.
FE International	Later, bigger deals	Six-figure+	High-touch brokerage above your starting range; their free guides are the best education available.

Start on **Acquire.com** and **Empire Flippers**; use Tiny Acquisitions or Motion Invest for a cheap, low-stakes first deal if you want to learn the mechanics before committing real money.

2.3 What you'll pay, and how deals are structured

Multiples (2025–2026). Profitable micro-SaaS trades around a **median 3.9× annual profit** (Acquire.com, Jan 2026): roughly 2–3× SDE at \$1–5k MRR, rising to 4–6× at ~\$10k MRR with low churn, and only reaching 7–9× for premium metrics (Rule of 40 > 50, net revenue retention > 120%). On a revenue basis, bootstrapped SaaS runs ~4–5× ARR, but the smallest deals run closer to ~3.3×. **Deal size is the single strongest predictor of the multiple** — small is cheap, which is good news for a buyer. (For reference only: content sites run ~30–40× *monthly* profit ≈ 2.5–3.3× annual, cut from higher levels because of Google/AI risk.)

The factors that move the price: growth is the biggest swing (each 10-point Rule-of-40 improvement ≈ +1.1× revenue multiple); lower churn commands a large premium (each 1-point monthly-churn reduction can lift a micro-SaaS value 15–25%); owner-passivity and diversified traffic earn premiums; single-keyword or single-customer concentration earns discounts.

Structure to shift risk back onto the (better-informed) seller:

- **Asset purchase (APA), not share purchase.** You buy the domain, code, accounts, and content — and only the liabilities you explicitly accept — avoiding the seller's unknown tax/legal exposure. Nearly all small online deals work this way.
- **Seller financing.** The online-deal norm is ~75% cash down with a short (often ~10-month), frequently 0%-interest payoff. A seller's willingness to hold a note is itself a signal — if they refuse, ask why.
- **Earnout.** Roughly 70% cash at close, ~30% contingent over 12–36 months. Tie the contingent part to **retention of existing customers**, not new-growth targets — cleaner to measure, harder to game.

- **Holdback/escrow.** Hold 10–20% for 12–24 months against the seller’s representations not holding up. Use a neutral escrow (Escrow.com, or the marketplace’s built-in escrow) and release only after you’ve verified every asset during the inspection window.

2.4 The rewrite trap (read this twice)

This is the failure mode most likely to bite *your* team specifically, because it is dressed up as good engineering.

When you buy one of these businesses, **the asset is the customers, the revenue, and the accumulated bug-fixes — not the code.** Joel Spolsky called a from-scratch rewrite “the single worst strategic mistake that any software company can make,” because throwing away working code discards years of hard-won fixes and hands your competitors a multi-year head start. Steve Blank named the specific way it kills an *acquisition*: a rewrite “condemns the old code before a viable alternative exists,” freezing the product while customers wait for features that never ship. Netscape rewrote and watched its market share collapse; Borland bought Arago, rewrote it, and Microsoft Access ate their lunch while they were busy. The near-miss that proves the rule: Less Annoying CRM began a full rewrite in 2012, froze the product, caught itself within a month, shipped incrementally instead — and grew to 2.5× the customers.

The psychology is exactly yours: good programmers look at inherited code, find it ugly, and feel certain they can do better. They’re usually wrong, because it is harder to read code than to write it, and that “mess” encodes years of edge cases. The disciplines that save you:

- **For the first 30–90 days, do not rewrite anything.** Talk to customers. Fix the highest-leverage small things. Learn the real operational load.
- **Modernize incrementally** using the strangler-fig pattern — replace the system piece by piece behind a stable interface, never all at once — and only where it demonstrably cuts cost or stops breakage.
- **Judge every change by customer value, not code aesthetics.** Customers are asking for reliability and features now, not for a prettier architecture later.

2.5 The other classic ways these deals fail

- **Adverse selection — “why is it really for sale?”** The seller always knows more than you and rationally lists at the peak of trailing metrics, often just before a decline they can already sense. (Cautionary tale: a Bain-trained buyer paid \$52,500 for an affiliate site at ~32× monthly, talked himself past the red flags, and watched it fall to ~\$5,000.) Defend with primary-source diligence and risk-shifting structure.
- **Single-channel dependency.** If one keyword, one platform, or one big client drives most of the value, you’re buying right as that channel can turn. Require at least two independent traffic/revenue sources.
- **“You’re buying a job.”** Technical buyers price the product and under-model the unglamorous recurring work — support, billing, refunds, dunning, account transfers. Experienced micro-acquirers estimate ops and growth are ~80% of the work, and

support doesn't scale like code. Systematize it (SOPs) and price the load into your offer.

- **Neglecting marketing/sales.** This is your named weakness, so confront it directly. "Build it and they will come" is dead — rough distribution math is ~10,000 impressions per paying customer, and the first ~1,000 customers of anything take about two years of effort. Either pick one repeatable acquisition channel and build an audience around it (the Arvid Kahl model, where content is the distribution), or accept that you're buying to harvest, not to scale — and buy accordingly.

2.6 Role models to learn from

- **Andrew Gazdecki (Acquire.com)** — design every business you own to be *sellable*: clean books, documented ops, strong margins. "Well-run" and "sellable" are the same thing.
 - **Andrew Wilkinson (Tiny)** — fund acquisitions from a boring cash-generating core, then "buy great businesses, hire great people, stay out of the way." Win deals by being the *easy* buyer (fast, no re-trading, fair price), not the highest.
 - **Mark Leonard (Constellation Software)** — buy sticky, mission-critical niche software cheaply; enforce an explicit return hurdle; be willing to walk; decentralize as you grow; never sell.
 - **Syed Balkhi (Awesome Motive)** — what you're really buying is the brand and the active user base; refocus a generic product on one niche, rebuild the UX incrementally, and "mind the terms, not just the valuation."
 - **Rob Walling (stair-step method)** — start small, master one acquisition channel, then step up. Going from 3 to 10 is far easier than 0 to 1.
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Part III — Structuring the business with Disciplined Entrepreneurship

Disciplined Entrepreneurship (Bill Aulet's 24 steps) was written for building an innovation-driven company from scratch. You're doing something different — buying companies that already have customers. So why use it at all? Because its core discipline is **relentless, evidence-based focus on the customer**, and that is exactly the rigor that makes someone a good *acquirer* and a good *operator*. Aulet's first commandment is blunt: "*The single necessary and sufficient condition for a business is a paying customer.*" An acquisition business is just a machine for buying, keeping, and multiplying paying customers. The framework fits better than it first appears.

The key adaptation is to apply the framework at **two levels**:

- **Portfolio level** — your company *as an acquirer*: which kind of business you hunt (your "beachhead"), what makes you uniquely good at owning them (your "Core"), and how you scale the roll-up.
- **Asset level** — each acquired product, run with DE rigor: who its users are, what you'll change, how you monetize, and how you validate each bet.

Aulet groups the 24 steps under six questions. Here is each one, translated.

Theme 1 — Who is your customer? (Steps 1–5, 9)

At the **portfolio level**, your “market segmentation” and “beachhead market” are not end users — they are the *category of businesses you buy*. Bending Spoons’ beachhead was mobile consumer apps; Constellation’s is vertical-market software. Yours should be a niche narrow enough that you build real pattern-recognition and reusable tooling: for example, “B2B micro-SaaS in a specific vertical (say, tools for accountants, or WordPress plugins for e-commerce), \$2k–\$20k MRR, subscription, organic acquisition, single-founder-run.” Write this down as a **buy box** (see §3.7). The discipline of Steps 1–4 — segment the options, pick *one* beachhead, size it — is exactly how you avoid the scattershot buying that kills roll-ups.

At the **asset level**, every time you buy, do Steps 3 and 5 properly for that product: build an **end-user profile** and a **persona** of the people who already pay. You inherited them; now understand them better than the previous owner did. Step 9 (“identify your next 10 customers”) becomes “understand who is *almost* buying and why they don’t” — your first, cheapest growth lever.

Theme 2 — What can you do for the customer? (Steps 6–8, 10, 11)

This theme is where you decide what to *change* post-acquisition. Run Step 6 (**full life-cycle use case**) to map how a user finds, adopts, pays for, and stays with the product, then find the broken or weak links — a clumsy onboarding, a missing integration, a slow feature. Step 8 (**quantify the value proposition**) forces you to state the improvement in the customer’s terms (“as-is vs. possible”), which is also how you justify a price increase without simply extracting.

Step 10 — Define your Core — is the most important step in this entire document for you. Aulet defines the Core as “*something that allows you to deliver the benefits your customers value with much greater effectiveness ... than any other competitor ... your business’s last defense against the competition.*” For an acquisition holding company, your Core is **not** any single product — products come and go. Your Core is the **repeatable operating system you build**: a shared platform (auth, billing, analytics, experimentation, support tooling) plus a proven post-acquisition playbook plus capital discipline. This is precisely what Bending Spoons’ “Spoon Engine” and Constellation’s decentralized VMS machine *are* — a Core that makes each new acquisition worth more in your hands than in anyone else’s. Aulet’s warning applies: the Core should stay fixed and be developed relentlessly; you change it only at your peril. Decide early that your Core is your operating platform, and invest in it from deal #1.

Step 11 (**competitive position**) is mapped per product against its real competitor — which, as Aulet notes, is usually the customer’s status quo and inertia, not another vendor.

Theme 3 — How does the customer acquire your product? (Steps 12–14)

Step 12 (**decision-making unit**) and Step 13 (**process to acquire a paying customer**) are about understanding, for each acquired product, who decides to buy and how the purchase

actually happens — then removing friction. Step 13A (**windows and triggers**) helps you find the moments that prompt a purchase (a new hire, a tax deadline, a project kickoff) so you can meet demand you don't have to manufacture — the closest thing to marketing that plays to a product team's strengths.

Step 14 (follow-on markets) is, at the portfolio level, your roll-up thesis. Once you own and understand one product in your niche, the adjacent businesses — complementary tools, the same customers' next need — become natural next acquisitions you can cross-sell into, exactly as Awesome Motive rolled up complementary WordPress plugins along a single customer value chain. Your first deal should ideally open a *door*, not just a revenue line.

Theme 4 — How do you make money? (Steps 15–19)

This is Bending Spoons' engine room and yours. Step 15 (**business model**) and Step 16 (**pricing framework**) are where the fastest post-acquisition wins usually live, because **most small software is badly underpriced by founders who feared charging more.** Raising a too-low price, adding an annual plan, or capping an over-generous free tier is frequently the single highest-ROI change you can make — with the discipline that you test it and watch whether revenue-per-user rises faster than users churn.

Steps 17 and 19 give you the two numbers that decide whether a business — and a *deal* — is viable: **lifetime value (LTV)** and **cost of customer acquisition (CoCA)**. Aulet's rule, borrowing David Skok's SaaS benchmark, is that **LTV should be at least 3× CoCA** — the cushion covers the over-optimism baked into both estimates and the shocks every business eventually hits. Use this twice: to judge the health of a business *before* you buy it, and to run it after. Step 18 (**scalable revenue engine**) is where you honestly confront your marketing gap: your LTV dictates which acquisition motions you can afford, and a low-touch, organic, product-led motion is both what suits your team and what you should preferentially buy.

Theme 5 — How do you design and build the product? (Steps 20–23)

Here the framework becomes your **acquisition diligence and integration discipline.** Treat every potential deal as a set of **key assumptions** (Step 20) to be **tested** (Step 21) *before* you wire the money — the seller's revenue is an assumption until you verify it against bank statements and Stripe exports (recall that 40%+ of these deals have inflated figures); the growth story, the churn, the traffic sources are all assumptions to test, not facts to accept.

Post-acquisition, Steps 22–23 reframe your product work: the **minimum viable business product** thinking keeps you from over-building, and “*show that the dogs will eat the dog food*” (Step 23 — measure real adoption, not opinions) is the standard for every change you ship. Combined with \$2.4's no-rewrite rule, this theme is your guardrail against the two developer temptations: buying on a good story instead of verified data, and rebuilding instead of measuring.

Theme 6 — How do you scale? (Step 24)

Step 24 (**product plan**) at the portfolio level is your **capital-allocation and platform roadmap**: the sequence in which you deploy cash flow into your shared Core and into the next acquisition. This is where you consciously choose to *be* a compounder — reinvesting earnings into (a) the platform that makes every future deal more valuable and (b) the next disciplined purchase — rather than a collector of unrelated apps. Bending Spoons, Constellation, and Tiny are all, at bottom, disciplined capital-allocation machines wrapped around an operating Core. That is the business you are actually building; the individual products are just where the customers live.

3.7 A concrete operating model for your company

Putting it together, here is a starting structure.

Legal / holding structure. A parent holding company owns each acquisition, ideally as a separate subsidiary or LLC per deal so that one product's liabilities are ring-fenced from the others. Buy via asset-purchase agreements. Keep clean, separate books per product from day one (it makes each one sellable later and makes your own diligence honest).

Capital plan — bootstrap and stair-step.

1. **Deal #1 (small, ~\$10k–\$75k):** one profitable micro-SaaS in your buy box, paid mostly in cash with a modest seller note. Goal: learn the full cycle end-to-end and start building the platform. Don't touch the product for 90 days.
2. **Deals #2–3:** slightly larger, funded from deal #1's cash flow plus seller financing. Start extracting shared services (billing, auth, analytics) into your Core.
3. **Beyond:** only once the platform and playbook are real, and only with carefully-sized debt, consider bigger deals. Never let the model come to depend on continuous outside capital — that is the one Bending Spoons lesson to *invert*.

Roles. Assign clear owners even in a small team: a **deal lead** (sourcing, diligence, negotiation), an **operator/platform lead** (integration, the shared Core), and — critically — someone who owns **distribution**. If nobody can or will own growth, decide deliberately that you are a *harvester* (buy stable, mature cash flows and optimize them) rather than a *scaler*, and set your buy box accordingly.

Your Core (the platform). Treat the shared platform as the company's crown jewel, per Step 10. Build it incrementally, pulling one reusable service out of each acquisition: unified billing/subscription management, authentication, product analytics and experimentation, a support/helpdesk stack, and eventually LTV-informed pricing. By deal #4 or #5, a new acquisition should plug into this and immediately get better checkout, better analytics, and your accumulated pricing learnings — your own miniature Spoon Engine.

The buy box (acquisition criteria). Write it down and enforce it like Constellation enforces its hurdle rate:

- Business type: subscription micro-SaaS or product-led tool (not content/FBA/ad-dependent)
- Niche: [your chosen vertical], where you'll build repeatable expertise
- Size: e.g. \$2k–\$20k MRR to start; price range \$10k–\$500k
- Health: verified LTV $\geq 3 \times$ CoCA; monthly churn $\leq \sim 3\text{--}4\%$; ideally flat-to-growing
- Acquisition: majority organic/word-of-mouth; ≥ 2 independent channels; no single customer $> \sim 15\text{--}20\%$ of revenue
- Tech: fully owned IP, transferable assets, tolerable (not necessarily pretty) code
- Deal: asset purchase; seller financing available; seller willing to hold a note and support transition

A first-90-days checklist per acquisition: verify all assets transferred and access secured (domains, repos, hosting, analytics, app-store and processor accounts — remember Stripe generally won't transfer, so plan the billing migration); talk to 10–20 customers; instrument the funnel; identify the two or three highest-leverage small fixes and the likely pricing change; *do not rewrite*; write the SOPs for support and ops. Only after this do you plan any modernization, incrementally.

A 12-month sketch. Quarter 1: define the buy box, set up the holdco, source ~ 50 targets, build a diligence checklist. Quarter 2: close deal #1; run the 90-day playbook; ship first small improvements and a tested price change. Quarter 3: stabilize, extract the first shared service into your platform, prove the unit economics. Quarter 4: close deal #2 from cash flow + seller financing; templatize everything you learned. Then repeat, faster and cleaner each time.

Appendix A — Bending Spoons acquisition timeline (selected)

Year	Target	Reported price	Post-deal signature move
2014	First keyboard app	\$10,000	Improved, $\sim$ doubled value
2021	Remini	undisclosed	Rebuilt; later App Store #1
2022	FiLMiC / FiLMiC Pro	undisclosed	Forced to subscription; original team let go
2023	Evernote	$\sim$ \$200M	$\sim 82\%$ staff cut; free tier $\rightarrow$ 50 notes; big price hike; monolith $\rightarrow$ microservices
2024	Meetup, Mosaic Group	undisclosed / $>$ \$100M	Mosaic's 330 staff not retained

2024	Hopin / StreamYard	undisclosed	Price +80% (\$25→\$45/mo)
2024	Issuu, WeTransfer	WeTransfer ~€716M	75% staff cut; free plan → 10 transfers/mo
2025	Brightcove	\$233M	Take-private; ~33% layoffs
2025	komoot	~€300M	~75% staff cut
2025	Harvest	undisclosed	Time-tracking/ invoicing
2025	Vimeo	\$1.38B	Take-private; deep layoffs
2025	AOL (from Yahoo)	~\$1.5B	Financed with ~\$2.8B debt package
2025	Eventbrite	~\$500M	vs. its \$1.76B 2018 IPO valuation
2026	Tractive	undisclosed	Closed just before IPO

Appendix B — Valuation multiples cheat sheet (2025–2026)

Asset type	Convention	Typical range	Watch-outs
Micro-SaaS (profit)	× annual profit/SDE	~2–3× (\$1–5k MRR) → 4–6× (\$10k MRR, low churn) → 7–9× (premium)	Churn and growth swing this hard
Bootstrapped SaaS (revenue)	× ARR	~3.3–5× (smaller = lower)	Deal size is the biggest driver
Content / affiliate	× monthly profit	~30–40× (≈2.5–3.3× annual)	Google/AI risk; avoid for now
Newsletter	× monthly profit or /subscriber	~30–45× monthly; \$1–10/sub	Engagement > list size
Shopify / DTC	× SDE/EBITDA	~3–5×	Ad-dependent
Amazon FBA	× SDE	~2.5–3.5×	Platform concentration discount

Appendix C — Due-diligence essentials

- **Revenue:** rebuild the P&L from *source data* (bank statements, Stripe/PayPal exports, processor dashboards), not the seller's summary. 40%+ of these deals carry inflated figures.
- **Traffic/demand:** map organic vs. direct vs. referral; view Google Search Console directly; inspect the *trend*, not just the snapshot; probe for past penalties or algorithm hits.
- **Churn:** benchmark monthly logo churn (~2–4% normal for SMB/prosumer); run cohort analysis — are newer cohorts retaining better or worse?
- **Tech & IP:** confirm *all* code and assets are owned by the entity (not a contractor); check for single-API/model dependence; assess real (not cosmetic) tech debt.
- **Concentration:** flag any customer > ~15–20% of revenue and any single traffic source > ~50%; check contracts for change-of-control clauses.
- **Transferability:** verify control *before* close — domains, hosting, repos, GA4/Search Console/Ads, email platform, affiliate and app-store/developer accounts, trademarks, licensed content. Assume payment processors (Stripe/PayPal) do **not** transfer; plan the billing migration and a revenue-continuity gap.
- **Key-person risk:** get SOPs and a transition agreement written into the APA.

Appendix D — The 24 steps, mapped to an acquisition business

Theme (Aulet's question)	Steps	Portfolio level (you as acquirer)	Asset level (each product)
Who is your customer?	1–5, 9	Define your buy box: the niche of businesses you hunt	Profile the users you inherited; find the near-buyers
What can you do for them?	6–8, 10, 11	Define your Core = your operating platform + playbook	Map the life cycle; fix weak links; quantify the value
How do they acquire it?	12–14	Follow-on markets = your roll-up / cross-sell thesis	Understand the DMU and purchase process; reduce friction
How do you make money?	15–19	Capital returns; LTV ≥ 3× CoCA as a <i>deal</i> filter	Pricing fixes; unit economics; organic revenue engine
How do you design/build?	20–23	Diligence = test key assumptions before you buy	MVBP discipline; measure adoption; no rewrites

How do you scale? 24

Capital allocation +
platform roadmap =
the compounder Product plan per
asset

Appendix E — Sources

Bending Spoons

- [TechCrunch — What is Bending Spoons? \(Jul 5, 2026\)](#)
- [TechCrunch — After \\$18B IPO, founder on “minimizing luck” \(Jul 1, 2026\)](#)
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- [Forbes — How Bending Spoons built an \\$18.4B empire \(Jul 1, 2026\)](#)
- [Axios — Bending Spoons CEO on future acquisitions \(Jul 1, 2026\)](#)
- [Mostly Metrics — Bending Spoons IPO S-1 breakdown](#)
- [Colin Keeley — Bending Spoons operating manual](#)
- [Wikipedia — Bending Spoons](#)
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Micro-acquisitions, valuation & deal mechanics

- [Acquire.com — Biannual Acquisition Multiples Report \(Jan 2026\)](#)
- [SaaS Capital — 2025 Private SaaS valuations](#)
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- [Empire Flippers — Scoreboard · How to value a website](#)
- [FE International — SaaS due-diligence checklist](#)
- [The Website Flip — Is website flipping profitable in 2025?](#)

On the rewrite trap and failure modes

- [Joel Spolsky — Things You Should Never Do, Part I](#)
- [Steve Blank — Startup Suicide: Rewriting the Code](#)
- [Less Annoying CRM — a rewrite cautionary tale](#)
- [Dana Hooshmand — my Empire Flippers failure story](#)
- [Jason Cohen — solve a real problem \(distribution math\)](#)

Framework

- [Bill Aulet, *Disciplined Entrepreneurship: 24 Steps to a Successful Startup* \(Expanded & Updated\) — provided by the client.](#)